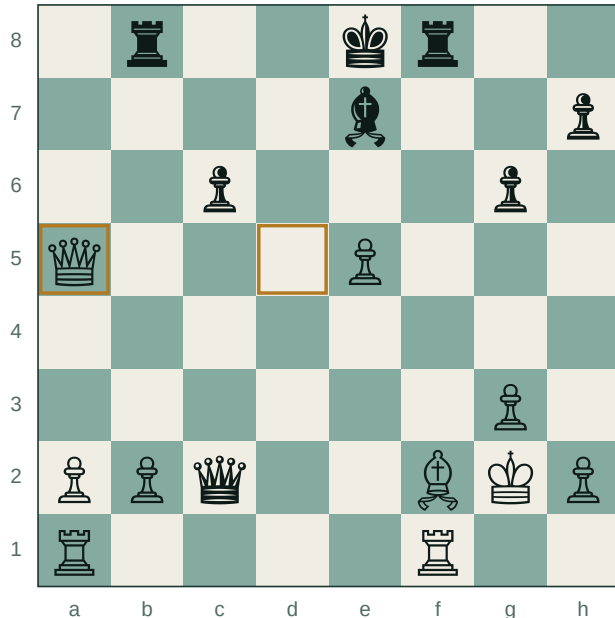


Active defensive resources: Black, move 34

Active defensive resources

Black to move



Previous move: 34.Qxa5. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

34...Rxb2 35. Qa8+ Bd8

34...Rxb2 The rook captures the pawn on b2. Recorded reply: **35.Qa8+**.

35...Bd8 The bishop moves from e7 to d8.

At the end, nominal material is White 26 / Black 25 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +1. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +1:** the balance goes from -2 to -1. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A defensive puzzle may aim to preserve equality rather than win. Judge success against the threat, not only the final material count.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

The best defense may create a threat, exchange an attacker, or change the geometry of the attack. Identify the opponent's concrete idea before selecting a response.

HOW TO LOOK

Name the threatened move and the conditions it requires. Look for a move that breaks one of those conditions with tempo.

The defending king is on g2. Absolute pin: bishop on f2.